WHAT'S PROMISED TO THEM

BHARATIYA JANATA PARTY

- Increase in the minimum support price (MSP) of major crops from time to time
- Strengthen PM Kisan, under which farmers are getting annual financial assistance of ₹6,000
- Self-sufficiency in producing key pulses and oilseeds; greater focus on natural farming and crop diversification
- Clusters for production of tomatoes, onions and potatoes with storage and logistics facilities
- Access to robust agri-infrastructure, including commitment to launch a dedicated indigenous Bharat Krishi Satellite

CONGRESS

- A legal guarantee to the MSP in line with the Swaminathan report
- Commission for Agricultural Costs and Prices, which recommends the MSP, will be made a statutory body
- A permanent commission on agricultural finance to monitor farm credit and address loan-related issues
- Regulated markets under the APMC Act; e-markets to operate under autonomous body
- Revive Agricultural Extension Services and open more Krishi Vigyan Kendras for technical aid

Aimed to deregulate the sector, the laws sought to give farmers more freedom to set prices directly with private businesses and enter into contract farming arrangements, intended to boost competition and investment in the agriculture sector. But in the absence of legally assured prices, farmers didn't have the confidence to enter into such arrangements with big corporate entities. As protests broke out in Punjab, Haryana and western Uttar Pradesh and farmers laid siege to the national capital for over a year, the government was forced to repeal the laws.

Having faced a setback on this front, the government moved towards strengthening cooperatives and setting up logistics and storage facilities. The continuity is reflected in the promises the BJP is making. Now, there is no space for flashy big ideas like the '5F' formula—Farm to Fibre to Fabric to Fashion to Foreign—for cotton growers that Modi had expounded in the run up to the 2014 general election in order to create a complete textile ecosystem in the country. The PM now talks about setting up new clusters for the production of staples instead—essentially an extension of the TOP (tomato, onion and potato) scheme run by the ministry of food processing industries. BJP leaders, at their rallies in Maharashtra, Chhattisgarh, Gujarat, Rajasthan and Uttarakhand, have also committed to pushing millet production and natural farming. The agriculture ministry is already planning ways to build the required market infrastructure and incentivise digital trading of commodities. There is also a commitment to crop diversification with an "appropriate" price support strategy. However, unlike the Congress, which has promised a legal guarantee to MSP, the BJP seems to be convinced that assured procurement and fixed prices are not good enough to build a robust marketplace for farm produce.

ALTHOUGH THE CONGRESS HAD OPPOSED THE FARM LAWS, IT IS PROMISING A MECHANISM FOR FARMERS TO SELL THEIR PRODUCE AT THE FARM GATE OR PLACE OF THEIR CHOICE

Who's their Custodian?

In poll season, it is no surprise that politics is being played over farmers' issues. In Himachal Pradesh, which goes to the polls on June 1, Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu of the Congress has squarely blamed the prime minister for allowing imports of apples from the US and denting the domestic prices. With the accusation severely hitting the prospects of BJP candidates in the apple belt, covering three of the hill state's four seats—Shimla, Mandi and Kangra—the saffron party turned the tables after the Congress announced former commerce minister Anand Sharma as its candidate from Kangra. The BJP leaders claim that Sharma was the one who signed the World Trade Organization's bound rates agreement, which caps the anti-dumping duty at 50 per cent.

Although the Congress had opposed the three farm laws, it is now making commitments to set up a mechanism for farmers to sell their produce at the farm gate or any other place of their choice with an option to upload the sale-and-purchase agreement on a digital ledger. In Maharashtra, along with the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) faction led by Sharad Pawar, it has proposed an